

McGraw Satisfied Metropolitan Fans By Getting Cohen And Hogan

By PAT ROBINSON

NEW YORK (INS)—For years and years, John McGraw tried to get a Jewish ball player of major league caliber and at last came up with Andy Cohen to play second base for the New York Giants.

At the same time McGraw landed Shanty Hogan, who was and is decidedly Irish, to catch and thereby pleased two large sections of the metropolitan fans.

McGraw had just gotten rid of Rajah Hornsby and the combination of circumstances led the late lyrical Bill Slocum to write:

"All your Cohens and Hogans can't begin to wear the brogans that Hornsby wore so well at second base."

Made Up At Gate

Slocum was correct from a playing standpoint, but as gate attractions Andy and Shanty more than made up for Hornsby's loss.

Years later, Branch Rickey,

then guiding the destiny of the Brooklyn Dodgers, made a pitch for the Negro fan dollar, by signing Jackie Robinson.

This move was both an artistic and financial success, for Jackie immediately began to make new fans wherever he appeared.

Other clubs saw the light, and today there are many Negro ball players scattered through the majors and minor leagues.

But fight promoters were away ahead of their baseball counterparts in building up big racial and religious followings for their fighters.

Tex Rickard, Mike Jacobs and many of the small clubs drew packed houses by skillfully matching Jewish boys like Benny Leonard with Italian lads like Johnny Dundee, or with Irish boys like Joe Shagroe.

These young fellows first built up tremendous followings in their own neighborhoods and later drew

them into Madison Square Garden and the ball parks.

Bid For Support

In recent years the fight promoters have made a big play for the Spanish-speaking fans by signing up fighters from Cuba, Puerto Rico, Mexico and various parts of South America.

This was a smart move for there are now more than one million Spanish-speaking persons in the metropolitan New York area.

The six-day bicycle promoters probably were the first to capitalize on athletes of various nationalities as drawing cards. There used to be 15 teams in every grind in the garden, and you could be sure that at least 20 different nations were represented among the riders.

And we note that in the recent grind in Cleveland there was a crack team from Spain, which was one of the few nations unrepresented in previous grinds.